

“The eradication of poverty in a country like India is simply not possible without the rational management of our environment…”

Anil Agarwal, 1985

After Independence, the Indian government emphasized the need for industrial development as a means of growing India’s economy and lifting millions out of poverty. Inevitably, this put immense pressure on the natural environment, with widespread deforestation occurring as trees were cut down to make way for factories, mines, commercial farms and areas of land submerged by the construction of dams.

Although these projects were meant to help the poor, it has often been the case that the poor face the brunt of the consequences of environmental damage, such as floods, landslides and other natural disasters with man-made causes. India’s wildlife, too, has come under threat, with